

OpenFirehouse handoff — 2026-08-04 PM (design-polish + setup wizard)

HANDOFF — 2026-08-04 PM · design-polish + the setup wizard

Read §0 before touching anything. The design work shipped; the more useful content of this handoff is *how five of my own checks were wrong*, because every one of them looked like a pass.

Session predecessor: `docs/HANDOFF-2026-08-04-DESIGN-POLISH-SESSION.md` (AM).

Program trust anchor: `docs/DESIGN-POLISH-GAMEPLAN-2026-08-04.md` . Critique snapshot: `.impeccable/critique/2026-08-04T21-58-49Z__client-src-components-departmentsetupwizard-jsx.md` .

0. STOP — the rules this session broke, in order of cost

1. Grepping a filename is not reading the file. Check whether TODAY already solved it.

Wiki anti-pattern **#60**, five instances in one evening. Two worth internalising:

- I hand-rolled an OKLCH→sRGB converter and reported **38 confident false failures** to Matt. `3ea090c` — *that same morning* — records the identical mistake on the NERIS panel and its fix: **let the browser convert via canvas**, sanity-checked white-on-black = 21.0.
- I escalated `text-gray-400` to Matt as a design-token decision needing his ruling. The same commit had already measured it (2.60 light / 3.67 dark), chosen `text-gray-500` `dark:text-gray-400` , and verified it (4.84 / 6.82). **The decision existed, with numbers.**

Before building a mechanism or escalating a decision: `git log --since="3 days ago" --<paths>` and **read the commit bodies** — in this repo they carry the reasoning and the

measurements. Before editing any file: `git log -3 -- <file> .`

2. A tool that writes must not describe itself as read-only. `e2e/scripts/contrast-report.mjs` said “reporting tool, not a gate” in its header and documented the prod `BASE` eleven lines above. Auditing the wizard means *advancing* it, and every `Next` runs `persistStep` → `PATCH /api/departments/:id` . **It renamed prod department 1 to “Contrast Audit FD”**. Restored by hand. The walk now refuses a non-localhost `BASE` unless `ALLOW_WRITES=1` .

3. Never commit a blocking gate you cannot pass. `e2e.yml` gates pushes AND PRs to `main` and calls that suite `BLOCKING`. I landed `09-contrast-sweep.spec.js` asserting zero failures; it failed **10/10** on a real, still-open defect. A red-on-arrival gate teaches everyone to ignore a red E2E, and the nine other journeys (incident lifecycle, inspection lifecycle, tenancy isolation) lose their signal with it. It is now a **ratchet** with baselines written down.

4. Do not baseline from an instrument you have not validated. My first ratchet numbers came from a run where `isFloating()` walked to the document root, so anything under a positioned ancestor was filed `uncertain` . Fixing it moved **16 real dark-mode failures per surface** into `failures` and immediately failed baselines I had written myself.

5. A silent bucket is how a defect hides. Four times in one file. See §3.

1. What shipped (all live on prod, all verified from served assets)

Area	Change
Demo	Every event was applied twice — <code>DemoTimeline</code> applied via <code>setIncident</code> AND bubbled to an <code>onEvent</code> <code>CommandBoard</code> re-applied. Doubled Radio Log, two IC cards. One writer now; <code>onEvent</code> plumbing deleted so it cannot return
ResponseMap	Opened on continental North America and never framed a CAD incident, because <code>typeof lat === 'number'</code> fails on

Area	Change
	Postgres NUMERIC-as-string. Frames the call, else the district
Forms app-wide	<code>color-scheme</code> was never declared, so Chrome styled every control for a light page: wizard inputs were #000 on #101828 = 1.18:1 , and every native <code><select></code> list rendered near-white options on a light OS popup $\approx 1.1:1$. Two lines in <code>index.css</code> bound to the <code>.dark</code> class
Setup wizard	Demo "Quick Setup" card (which wrote a fictional department into the real one) gated to <code>?demo=1 /dev</code> · half-filled apparatus/partner rows no longer silently discarded · station removal confirms and names the rigs it will move · HQ address/city/state now persist · all 10 step-1 controls <code>id / htmlFor</code> associated · 14px remove buttons $\rightarrow$ 44px · <code>focus-visible</code> rings (buttons had none) · type floor 10px $\rightarrow$ 11px
Login	Hardcoded <code>initials: 'DR'</code> on Sarah Chen $\rightarrow$ derived from the name · unreadable <code>gray-400</code> body text · hover states had no dark variants · card list widened so highlights stop wrapping mid-phrase
Top bar	Assistant badge was absolutely positioned at the button's own corner, covering its label — read "Assistan" . Now inline; <code>purple-500</code> $\rightarrow$ <code>violet-600</code>
Violet vocabulary	<code>data/auth.js</code> role palette (<code>training_captain</code> was violet), "New Meeting" red $\rightarrow$ violet gradient, PersonalAssistant <code>purple-600</code>

Area	Change
Radio Log	indigo → sky, with contrast measured: sky-600 on white is 4.09:1 and fails, so tokens are sky-700
Tooling	client/src/lib/a11y/contrastAudit.js + e2e/journeys/09-contrast-sweep.spec.js (ratchet gate) + e2e/scripts/contrast-report.mjs (grouped report)

Reverted deliberately: my edits to `StationSettings.jsx` and `NFIRSForm.jsx` (7643cc0). See §4.

2. PICK UP HERE

Highest value, in order:

1. **Wizard steps 5–9 have no measured pass.** Steps 1–4 measured (281/268/379 nodes; 16 dark / 49 light). The walk stopped at a deadlock I had introduced; that is fixed, so re-run and it should reach Launch:

```
cd e2e && BASE=http://localhost:5173 node scripts/contrast-report.mjs
```

Localhost only — the walk writes. Do not claim any step clean without a number.

2. **Close** text-gray-400 **against the established pair.** Not a decision — precedent from 3ea090c is text-gray-500 dark:text-gray-400 (4.84 / 6.82). It is the dominant remaining cluster (2.49–2.6:1 on light surfaces, many files, 10–12px). Fix by cluster, per-instance verified; **never a codemod from detector output** (gameplan ruling #4). Lower the ratchet caps as you go.
3. **Light mode carries ~3× the failures of dark** (49 vs 16 on the wizard). The app is dark-first and light is under-exercised.

4. `Feed down` · `polling` **on prod Live Dispatch**, seen twice today. Per the repo's own realtime notes this outranks cosmetics if real — verify from the served bundle + a live probe, never from a green deploy.

Open decisions for Matt (do not invent answers): - Bell badge (47) vs Notifications card (36) — legitimately different definitions, same apparent label. Fix by **labelling**; never change the arithmetic. - Version renders `v0.13.0.13` (semver + `buildNumber` 13, deliberate). Reads as a typo; proposed `v0.13.0+13`. - **The nine-step wizard shape.** The `/impeccable` critique scored it **18/40 (Poor)** and argued a volunteer department has one answer to six of the nine steps. `singleStation` already proves the wizard can reshape itself; it does so twice. This is a product conversation, not a design pass. - **FDID: resolve, don't type.** `7e720af` replaced a hand-typed NERIS entity ID with a registry-backed picker because *"a transcription slip either fails at submit or resolves to ANOTHER department, putting this department's reports on a stranger's national record."* FDID is the same class of field and today only got help text. The pattern already exists in this codebase.

3. The auditor's four buckets — do not collapse them

`failures` (normal flow, DOM backdrop IS the painted backdrop — trustworthy) · `uncertain` (fixed/sticky/absolute — GO LOOK) · `exempt` (disabled controls, WCAG 1.4.3 excludes them) · `unmeasurable` (native `<select>` chrome is OS-painted and cannot be read from the DOM at all, plus an assertion that `color-scheme` is declared).

Each bucket exists because that category was, at some point in one afternoon, reported as a defect or as a pass when it was neither. **Known remaining limits, documented so they are not mistaken for covered cases:** `opacity`, `mix-blend-mode` and `backdrop-filter` are ignored; `color()` / `lab()` / `lch()` are unparsed (they now fail closed rather than guessing). The audit's recommendation for the parser is the **canvas normaliser** — which is also what `3ea090c` used. Use that, not more regex.

4. Do not re-do these

- `StationSettings.jsx` and `NFIRSForm.jsx` **are reverted on purpose.** `StationSettings` is the NERIS department picker (seven commits on 08-03/04,

incl. ToU §5 hyperlink and ToU §2 automated-retrieval decisions). `NFIRSForm` is gated `status: 'planned'` — `moduleRegistry.js:36`, “*NFIRS retired nationally 2026-01*”. **NERIS is the authoritative record, not NFIRS.** I called that file “the legal record” and was wrong.

- `constants/usStates.js` stays, used **only** by the setup wizard. Do not “unify” the other lists without a reason that survives those seven commits.
- The impeccable detector reports 3 findings on `DepartmentSetupWizard.jsx` — **all verified false positives** (line 54 pairs a base text colour with a *hover* background; line 916 is a three-branch ternary whose flagged pairs are mutually exclusive on `i` vs `step`).
- Side-tab status stripes are waived (gameplan ruling #1). Violet = AI only (#2).

5. State of the world

- **Server suite: 1069 tests, 1067 pass, 0 fail** (`TENANCY_TEST_DB` set). Client build green. Contrast gate 11/11 against prod.
- Migration head **0124**. This session created none.
- **Pinecone: OVER ITS MONTHLY EMBEDDING QUOTA. Do not run the sync or a search, do not retry, do not “check if it’s back.”** The corpus is stale and the four-tool lookup is down to three. When the wiki is thin, say the corpus search was unavailable — a 429 is not “no hits”.
- **NotebookLM: use** `Skill(notebooklm)` **for any NotebookLM operation**, and route the CLI through `mcp__desktop-commander__start_process`. Never pip-install it or run `notebooklm login` in the sandbox (anti-pattern #10). `9c8f` refreshed this session: `refreshed: 1, unchanged: 21, verify_failed: 0`.
- Prod department name **restored** to “Maplewood VFD” and read back after my tool renamed it.
- Concurrent session: another Claude was working the permits/prevention register in this repo all evening. Stage explicit paths only; **never** `git commit -a`.